04 3–4 LAYING HENS THE CHICKEN COOP

A predator-proof coop for a small flock that lives largely on kitchen scraps.

LEVEL	CREW	WHERE	STAGE NOW
■□□ Open to all	1–3	To be decided (near the kitchen shed and the garden)	Location, build, sourcing hens

Three or four hens, a coop they can't be stolen from, a waterer that stays clean, and a diet built around kitchen scraps. In a canyon next to the Angeles National Forest, the coop's main job is to keep coyotes, bobcats, raccoons, hawks and possibly bears out.

FIRST STEPS *today*

1. Walk the land with Yusuf and pick the spot: dry high ground, afternoon shade, near the kitchen shed for scraps and the garden for manure, as far from neighbors as practical.
2. Mark a 4 × 4 ft coop and a run of at least 5 × 8 ft with stakes and string.
3. Dig the trench for the buried hardware-cloth apron around the run.
4. Set the coop frame on concrete blocks or skids, 12–18 in off the ground.
5. Start the DIY water nipple bucket (below).

BEFORE YOU START

- **No heat lamp.** Heat lamps are a leading cause of coop fires, and this is a wildfire canyon. Grown hens handle LA winters fine in a dry, draft-free coop.
- Scraps attract rats. Feed only what the hens finish by evening, and keep feed in a metal can with a lid.
- Wash hands after handling hens or cleaning the coop (salmonella).

THE BASICS

Space	Inside the coop: at least 4 sq ft per hen (16 sq ft for four, e.g. 4 × 4 ft). Run: at least 10 sq ft per hen (40 sq ft or more). Bigger is better.
Inside	Roost bar 8–10 in of length per hen, 2–3 ft off the floor and higher than the nest boxes. One or two nest boxes about 12 × 12 in. Vents near the roof.
Predator-proofing	Use ½ in hardware cloth, not chicken wire (chicken wire keeps chickens in, not predators out). Bury an apron 12 in down or out around the run. Roof the run. Use two-step latches; raccoons open simple ones.
Heat is the real threat	Site for afternoon shade. A light-colored metal roof reflects heat and doesn't burn.
Rules	Hens are allowed in much of unincorporated LA County; roosters are restricted (2018 ordinance). Yusuf checks distance-from-dwelling rules for this parcel.

HOW-TO NOTES

Water nipple bucket	A food-grade 5-gallon bucket with a lid. Drill 11/32 in holes in the bottom, wrap the nipple threads in plumber's tape, and screw in 3–4 vertical nipples. Hang it so the nipples sit just above the hens' heads. Tap a nipple so a drop forms and they'll learn fast. Keep the bucket in shade. Cost: about $15–25.
Feeding on scraps	Layer feed is the base for steady eggs and strong shells; scraps stretch it. A hen eats about ¼ lb of feed a day, so four hens on feed alone go through a 40-lb bag in about 6 weeks. With scraps and foraging covering a big share, one bag can last 2–3 months. Always offer oyster shell (calcium) and grit free-choice.
Stretching feed the old way	Ferment it: soak the feed in water for 2–3 days, stirring daily. It's more digestible and goes further. Let the hens work the compost pile for bugs.
Never feed	Avocado skin or pit, raw or dried beans, anything moldy, chocolate, salty or processed food, green potato peels.
Light without a lamp	For winter light or a frost-night heated waterer: a 10–30W solar panel, charge controller, small 12V battery and 12V LED on a timer. Or let the hens rest; laying slows naturally in winter.

THE PLAN *in order*

01	**Site + size**	Location, footprint, fixed coop or movable "chicken tractor".
02	**Frame**	Coop on blocks or skids; run framed.
03	**Wire**	Hardware cloth on every opening, apron buried, run roofed.
04	**Roof**	Light-colored metal sheet.
05	**Fit-out**	Roosts, nest boxes, vents, doors, two-step latches, deep litter (straw, leaves, pine shavings).
06	**Feed + water**	Nipple bucket, a covered or treadle feeder (keeps rats out), oyster shell.
07	**Hens**	3–4 birds of the same age, kept in the coop 3–5 days so they learn home.

TOOLS & MATERIALS

- ½ in hardware cloth
- 2×4s, plywood, screws
- Metal roofing sheet
- Concrete blocks
- Staple gun + washers/screws for the wire
- Food-grade bucket + 3–4 nipples, 11/32 in drill bit
- Shovel for the apron
- Two-step latches, hinges

FOR YUSUF TO DECIDE

- ? Coop location
- ? Fixed or movable
- ? Breeds: Australorp, Easter Egger, Leghorn (heat-tolerant), Barred Rock
- ? Pullets or rescued hens
- ? Solar light: yes or no

Resources: Pullets (18–22 wks): feed stores in spring, 4-H families, farm groups · Rescued ex-commercial hens: Animal Place rehoming (animalplace.org) · Selling eggs requires CDFA egg registration (cdfa.ca.gov)